

Chapter 189 - Part 1

Extra 11-1

The day Zhao Xuning and Shen Hui went to register their marriage, it rained.

The date was chosen casually.

Though calling it casual wasn't quite accurate. It was just that the night before, after Zhao Xuning finished her bath, she stood by the window overlooking the night scene below.

She and Shen Hui had moved back to where they lived during university.

Looking down from above, one could see the medical university at a glance.

The days seemed to have returned to when they first met.

But in reality, they hadn't.

Both of them knew that now was different from before.

No one took the initiative to bring up the matter of the little one. They were living their normal lives, dating, no longer making things difficult for each other.

Just that there was less intimacy between them.

Perhaps it was because time had passed, or perhaps it was the distance that came from putting a broken mirror back together.

When Shen Hui called Zhao Xuning, she no longer called her "wife" or "baby" in that soft, sweet way, but rather lazily and casually called her by name.

Really calling out her full name, surname and all.

Zhao Xuning felt disoriented several times, as if they weren't together.

But they quickly moved in together again.

In the dim yellow light, on the soft bed, Shen Hui's voice was still no different. Her fingers would still scratch heavily across Zhao Xuning's back like before, but after they finished, Shen Hui could always detach herself quickly.

Zhao Xuning couldn't help but think of the past again.

Back then, after they finished, Shen Hui would always burrow into her arms, even if their bodies were sweaty and sticky.

Zhao Xuning didn't really like this feeling. Especially at first, her cleanliness obsession and OCD made it so she had to shower after finishing, but Shen Hui would hold her back, trapping her on the bed with both legs, then rolling into her arms acting cute: "Wife, hug me~"

Her voice was extremely lazy from the exhaustion after their activities.

There were times when Zhao Xuning ignored her coquetry and got up to shower.

But when she came out after showering, all the lights in the room would be turned off, and Shen Hui would be curled up under the covers, her shoulders shaking.

When she cried, her eyes would turn red, her light brown pupils beautiful beyond words.

Always arousing Zhao Xuning's desire again.

Later on, no one knew if it was Zhao Xuning bullying Shen Hui until she cried, or if Shen Hui just liked to cry.

Back then, Zhao Xuning always said she was a crybaby.

When Shen Hui first met Zhao Xuning, Zhao Xuning didn't have the habit of carrying tissues. She was more likely to carry wet wipes.

Those single-pack wet wipes—she'd usually have two or three on her.

But later, Zhao Xuning developed the habit of carrying tissues with her.

Because Shen Hui's tear ducts were too active.

Zhao Xuning was often afraid of making her cry, yet also liked making her cry.

But back then, they seemed very intimate. Intimate enough to eat from the same plate, sleep under the same blanket, embrace each other on hot summer days, share the same takoyaki¹ in winter, and walk hand in hand at night markets.

But now the distance was close, yet also far.

Breaking the ice required just one sentence.

But making all the ice melt and blend with the originally calm water seemed very difficult.

Zhao Xuning didn't know what to do.

So after finishing her shower, she stood by the window and saw not far away a red neon sign, connected to form their school's name.

Inexplicably, she suddenly thought of marriage.

If they got married, would things be different?

Zhao Xuning thought, probably they would be.

If the relationship couldn't break through the ice, then they'd take it a step further.

When Shen Hui came out after showering, Zhao Xuning's hair was already almost dry. She still took out the hairdryer, having Shen Hui lean against the sofa, basically falling into her arms, gently and slowly blow-drying Shen Hui's hair.

Zhao Xuning's movements were very light.

The moment the hairdryer sound stopped, Zhao Xuning suddenly said: "Ah Hui, let's get married."

Shen Hui had been playing with a rubber band in her hands. Hearing her say this, the taut rubber band suddenly snapped.

The particularly loud sound made the space feel oppressive.

The rubber band happened to snap against Shen Hui's finger, immediately leaving a red mark.

It hurt so much she drew in a sharp breath.

Zhao Xuning immediately picked up her finger, frowning. After looking, it really wasn't a serious wound, but the instant a rubber band snaps against a finger, the pain truly strikes at the heart.

But Shen Hui wasn't paying attention to this.

She was more concerned with Zhao Xuning's words, but when the words reached her lips, she didn't know how to ask.

Zhao Xuning lowered her head, seriously rubbing her finger, trying to disperse that red mark, but the red mark kept expanding.

Zhao Xuning suddenly gently took her finger into her mouth.

Shen Hui could just see the top of her head, and Zhao Xuning's falling hair strands also happened to land on the back of Shen Hui's hand.

Even her hair carried warmth.

Shen Hui responded softly: "Mm."

Zhao Xuning's spine stiffened.

Shen Hui pulled her finger out and patted her back lightly, "Go get some alcohol."

Zhao Xuning: "?"

Although she didn't know what Shen Hui wanted to do, Zhao Xuning obediently did it.

She poured the alcohol for Shen Hui, then sat beside her, at a loss.

After a few glasses of alcohol, Shen Hui finally asked: "Zhao Xuning, do you still like me?"

Zhao Xuning had also drunk a few glasses, drinking hastily. After finishing, her face slightly flushed, she leaned close to Shen Hui and when she wasn't paying attention, secretly kissed her, then sat up straight all proper and serious, "I like you."

Shen Hui asked again: "Why do you want to marry me?"

Zhao Xuning: "..."

This question stumped Zhao Xuning. But after thinking about it, she finally sighed and said: "Ah Hui."

Zhao Xuning hugged her waist. The way she called her was intricate and winding, tender and gentle, "I want to be properly together with you."

Not the kind where they tortured each other.

The kind where they loved each other and could embrace each other.

She thought the three thousand steps were the end.

But later discovered that was merely the fuse to start over.

Now the fuse was still burning, and this fuse seemed to have no end.

Both of them were damp; no matter how the fuse crackled, it wouldn't ignite.

Zhao Xuning said: "Shen Hui, I want to love you properly."

Shen Hui asked her: "What counts as loving properly?"

Zhao Xuning thought for two seconds: "Mm... I don't know how to say it."

Shen Hui stared at her, then after a moment smiled, "Fool."

Both reproachful and shy.

But later, after drinking too much, Shen Hui and Zhao Xuning kissed during their eye contact. Shen Hui asked hazily: "Will it be sunny tomorrow?"

Zhao Xuning nodded: "Mm."

"Then let's get married."

And so, on a day that wasn't particularly special, the two decided on marriage.

But they didn't expect it would be a rainy day.

Footnotes:

¹ Takoyaki (章魚小丸子) - A Japanese snack/street food consisting of balls of batter filled with octopus, also known as octopus balls